



10Power IoT Fellowship

in collaboration with **NESL** (New Energy Solutions Lab)

Continuous Residual-Current (Leakage) Detection for Distributed Energy Management

Integrating the IVY MD0630 Type-B RCM into the OpenAMI / MeshEMS firmware:
from Modbus bring-up to multi-EMS isolation and
reverse-flow-adaptive protection

Consolidated technical report, sprints S1 to S6

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Target platform

NESL EMS controller (ESP32-S3, PCB 865B)
Firmware branch `modbus-testing`

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Summary

This report summarises the work carried out over six sprints (S1 to S6) to integrate the **IVY MD0630 Type-B AC+DC leakage sensor** (a residual-current monitor, RCM) into the **OpenAMI / MeshEMS** EMS firmware. The sprints were:

- **S1**: bring up the Modbus link and derive the register map.
- **S2**: read the live AC/DC leakage on the ESP32.
- **S3**: write the safety thresholds, always confirmed by a read-back.
- **S4**: add an energy-change correlation cache.
- **S5**: build a multi-EMS nomination and MQTT isolation scheme.
- **S6**: sense the hardware alarm outputs and adapt the AC threshold under reverse power flow.

Each sprint below gives its objective, method and result. The work followed the “**path of least blockage**” approach: build with configurable parameters and a mock pipeline so progress never stalls on an unknown, then confirm each assumption on real hardware.

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Nomenclature

Term	Meaning
AC / DC	Alternating / direct current component of the residual current
CRC	Cyclic redundancy check (Modbus frame integrity)
EMS	Energy Management System (the NESL ESP32-S3 controller)
FC	Modbus function code (FC03 read, FC06 write-single, FC16 write-multiple)
GPIO	General-purpose input/output pin
LV	Low voltage
MQTT	Message Queuing Telemetry Transport (publish/subscribe messaging)
PV / EV	Photovoltaic / electric vehicle
RCD / RCM	Residual-current device (protective) / monitor (measuring)
RCM Type B	Monitor that senses AC and DC residual current
RS-485 / UART	Serial physical / logic layers

1 Context and objectives

The **IVY MD0630** is a Type-B residual-current monitor: it measures both the AC and the DC component of the earth-leakage current. A Type-B device is used on sites with power electronics (PV, battery storage, EV charging), where a DC residual current can appear and would not be seen by an ordinary AC-only RCD.

The sensor is a subsystem of the NESL **Energy Management System (EMS)**, an ESP32-S3 controller (PCB 865B) that meters energy, drives relays and speaks MQTT within the OpenAMI / MeshEMS platform. Because several EMS can share one low-voltage feeder, the leakage can be handled in a coordinated, multi-node way.

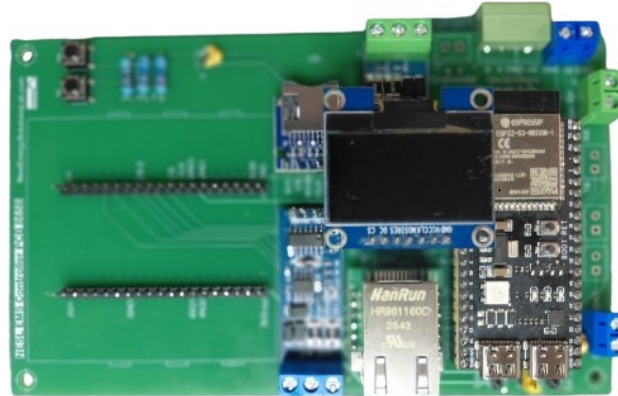


Figure 1: The NESL Street-EMS controller, the class of ESP32-S3 device into which the leakage subsystem is integrated.

Objective. Integrate the Type-B leakage monitor into the EMS firmware so the platform reads and acts on the residual current continuously. The work was split into the six sprints of Table 2.

Table 2: The six sprints of the assignment.

Sprint	Objective	Outcome
S1	Modbus bring-up and register map	Map derived, confirmed vs vendor tool
S2	Read live AC/DC leakage on the EMS	12/12 reads, 0 failures
S3	Write safety thresholds, with read-back	Solved via FC16 (not FC06); verified
S4	Correlate leakage changes with energy	Cache implemented and exercised
S5	Multi-EMS nomination and MQTT isolation	Proven on device and over MQTT
S6	Hardware alarm sense and reverse-flow threshold	Implemented; alarm path verified on HW

2 S1: Modbus bring-up and register map

Objective. Establish Modbus communication with the module and derive its register map (offsets, function code, scaling), which the datasheet does not give. This was done first on a PC bench, before committing the EMS bus.

Method. The module was powered at 12 V and read through a USB-TTL adapter as the Modbus master. The detail that unblocked communication was electrical: the module’s UART is open-drain and needs pull-ups, and (because the lab adapter had no VCC wire) those pull-ups were fed from an ESP32 5 V pin, with every ground tied to a single common ground (Figure 2). Once the link was up, the register block was found by scanning, then every field was cross-checked against IVY’s own `CT.exe` tool.

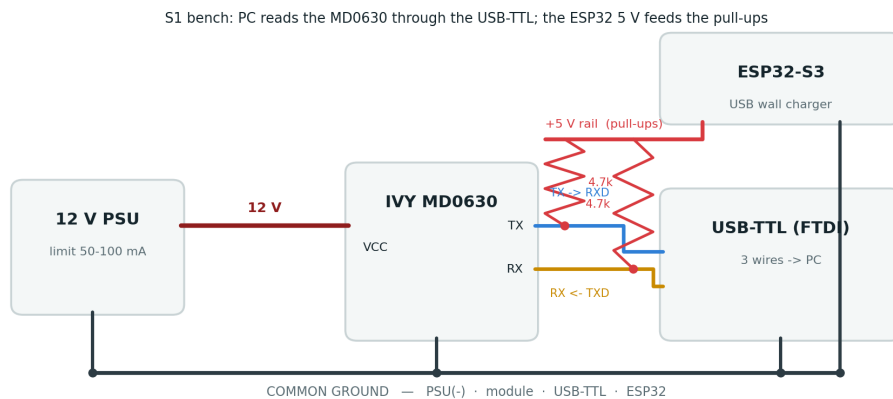


Figure 2: S1 bench wiring: 12 V powers the module; the PC reads it over the USB-TTL; the ESP32 5 V feeds the pull-ups; every ground is common.

Table 3: Derived MD0630 register map (FC 0x03, scaling raw $\times 0.1$ mA). Defaults match the datasheet: DC 6 mA, AC 30 mA.

Register	Default (raw / $\times 0.1$ mA)	Field	Access
0x0000	0 / 0.00	DC leakage current	R
0x0001	0 / 0.00	AC leakage current	R
0x0002	60 / 6.0	DC threshold	R/W
0x0003	300 / 30.0	AC threshold	R/W
0x0100	1	Version	R
0x0111	5	Minor version	R

S1 result

Communication established at **address 1, 9600 8N1, FC 0x03, scaling raw $\times 0.1$ mA**, and the register map (3) was derived from the live device and confirmed against the vendor’s CT.exe frames.

3 S2: Live AC/DC read on the EMS

Objective. Have the EMS itself read the live residual current over its own serial bus, and feed the values into the firmware’s leakage model (published on the `subpanel_RCmleaks` topic).

Method. The MD0630 uses plain UART (not RS-485 differential), so it connects directly to the ESP32 UART pins, no transceiver (Table 4). Pull-ups go to 3.3 V, since the ESP32-S3 GPIOs are not 5 V-tolerant.

Table 4: S2 bench wiring, direct UART.

Module	ESP32-S3	Note
TX	GPIO42 (RS485_1 RX)	+ 4.7 k Ω pull-up to 3V3
RX	GPIO7 (RS485_1 TX)	+ 4.7 k Ω pull-up to 3V3
GND	GND	common ground (EMS, module, 12 V PSU—)
VCC	12 V PSU	never the ESP32

S2 bench: ESP32 reads the MD0630 directly on its UART (GPIO42/7); 3.3 V feeds the pull-ups

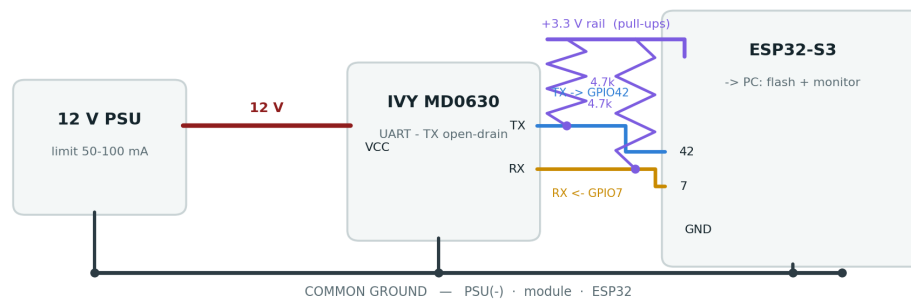


Figure 3: S2 bench wiring: the EMS reads the MD0630 directly on its UART (GPIO42/7); the module runs on 12 V; the ESP32 3.3 V feeds the pull-ups; every ground is common.

Two issues were found and fixed: the data wires were first landed on the board’s silkscreen “RX/TX” (the USB console UART, GPIO44/43) instead of the Modbus bus (GPIO42/7); and the on-board SHT20 sensor, also at address 1, collided with the CT on the bus until a bring-up flag skipped its poll.

S2 result

The EMS reads the physical module reliably: **12 consecutive successful reads, 0 failures**, both channels 0.00 mA at rest. The S1 register map is validated on the target hardware.

4 S3: Config-time threshold writes

Objective. Write the safety thresholds (DC 6 mA at 0x0002, AC 30 mA at 0x0003) at commissioning time, always confirmed by a read-back, and never from the polling loop.

Method and finding. The first attempt used **FC 0x06 (write single register)**. The module accepted it (no Modbus exception) but silently ignored it: the register did not change, and only the read-back caught it. Sniffing the vendor tool doing a write showed the reason:

```
Write : 00 10 00 03 00 01 02 01 0E 2B A7    (FC 0x10, reg 0x0003, qty 1, value 0x010E = 270
Read  : 00 10 00 03 00 01 F0 18              (success; no unlock frame anywhere)
```

The MD0630 requires **FC 0x10 (write multiple registers)**, and there is no unlock step. The driver's `writeThreshold mA()` now writes via FC16 and enforces a read-back:

Table 5: The write is never trusted without a matching read-back.

Step	Action
1	<code>setTransmitBuffer(0, mA × 10)</code> , e.g. 30 mA → 300 = 0x012C

Step	Action
2	<code>writeMultipleRegisters(reg, 1),</code> FC 0x10 to 0x0002 (DC) or 0x0003 (AC)
3	40 ms settle, then read back (FC 0x03)
4	Confirm: read-back == written → OK; else reject (0xE4)

On the EMS this swept AC 30 → 27 → 30 mA with matching read-backs, then restored the safe factory defaults (DC 6 / AC 30 mA).

S3 result

Threshold writes work via **FC 0x10 with a mandatory read-back**, verified on the EMS. The blocker was the function code (FC06 vs FC16), found by tracing the vendor tool, not an unlock step.

Following the agreed safety rules, writes are config-time only, target only the two threshold registers, always read back and reject on mismatch, and the vendor tool's factory Calibration function is never used.

5 S4: Energy-change correlation

Objective. Add a cache so that, whenever the leakage steps up or down, the system can look back over recent energy activity and record what energy event happened at that moment. This is the input the S5 manager consumes.

Method. Two streams meet in the cache (Figure 4). The EMS energy (`readings[0]`) is recorded continuously into a ring buffer of 128 timestamped snapshots, each deriving the active-power ramp against the previous sample. The leakage reading drives a step detector that fires when the change is at least 1 mA; on a step it queries the ring for the nearest snapshot within a 2 s window and attaches it to the event.

S4 - a leakage step is matched to the energy event around it (+/- window)

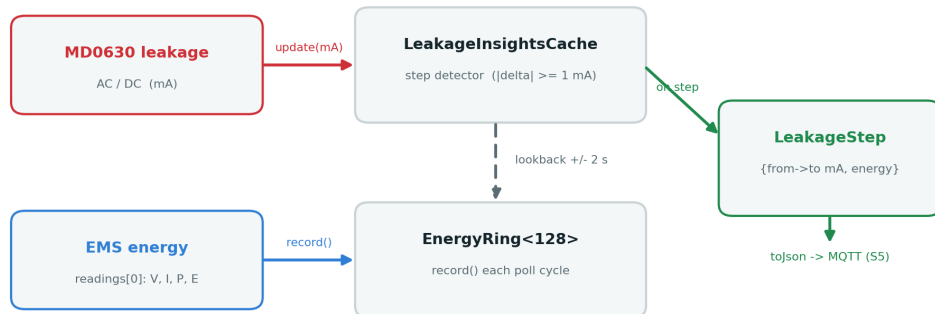


Figure 4: S4 data flow: a leakage step is matched to the energy event around it (within a time window).

The design is change-based, not level-based (it acts on steps, not the always-present standing residual), and the energy ring is generic so the same pattern is reusable for other insights. A `phase_angle_deg` field is reserved for a future RCM upgrade that would give leakage direction.

S4 result

An energy-change correlation cache (`EnergyRing`, `LeakageInsightsCache`) links each leakage step to the surrounding energy event. It compiles and is exercised end to end by the mock ramp.

6 S5: Multi-EMS nomination and MQTT isolation

Objective. When several EMS share a feeder, a single leak is seen (at different magnitudes) by several of them. S5 decides which EMS is nearest the fault and how to isolate it. The scheme is grounded in the fault-location literature (references [1] and [2]).

Method. Nomination ranks candidates by magnitude and by lowest peer-correlation (the “odd one out”, the node whose ramp signature correlates least with its peers), and a confidence gate decides between auto-isolation (bracket the two EMS around the leak) and alert-only. The detection triggers on change, not on absolute level. A residual-voltage / residual-current phase-angle criterion is noted as the basis for a future direction feature, tied to the reserved `phase_angle_deg` field.

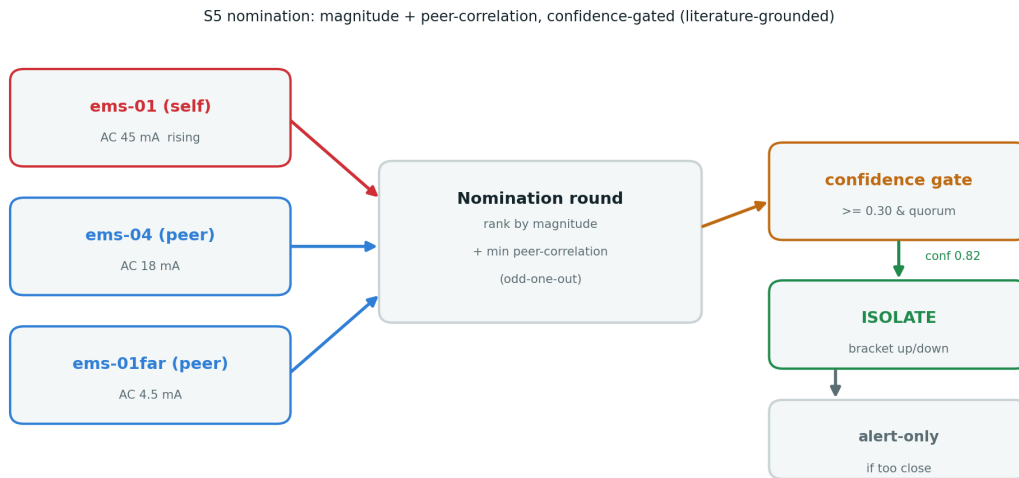


Figure 5: S5 nomination flow: rank by magnitude and by minimum peer-correlation, confidence-gated to auto-isolate or alert-only.

Evidence. The `LeakageInsightsManager` implements a per-EMS state machine (`normal`, `watch`, `isolating`, `fault`, `restored`) and the three MQTT payloads. Run on one ESP32 with two simulated peers (mid $\approx 0.4\times$, far $\approx 0.1\times$), the nominated node is both the magnitude leader and the least-correlated node, giving confidence 0.82 and an auto-isolate decision. The leakage was then streamed over MQTT to a broker on the PC over a real WiFi network, and charted live as the mock ramp rose and held at its ceiling (figures below).

Figure: Live leakage telemetry charted in MQTT Explorer (`rcm_ac_mA` / `rcm_dc_mA`).

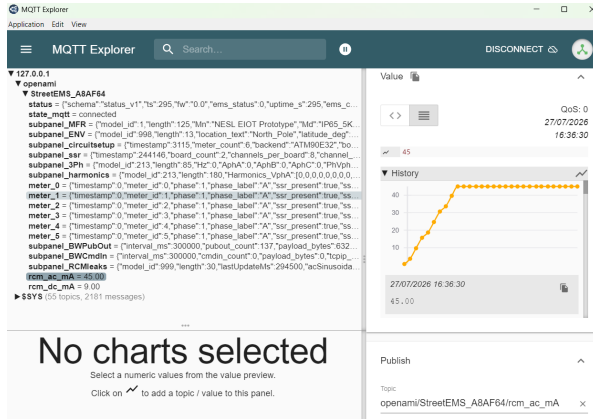


Figure 6: AC leakage rising to 45 mA then holding.

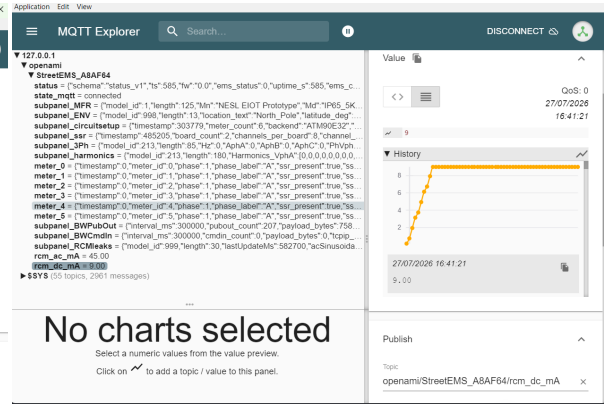


Figure 7: DC leakage rising to 9 mA then holding.

S5 result

The nomination (magnitude and peer-correlation, confidence-gated) locates a leak across three EMS on one ESP32, and the live leakage streams over MQTT with a fault flag and live charts. A WPA3/PMF hotspot blocked the ESP32's WiFi stack; a WPA2 hotspot connected immediately.

7 S6: Hardware alarm sense and reverse-flow threshold

S6 has two parts (Figure 8): the EMS observes the module's own hardware alarm (A), and it adapts the AC threshold to the site's power-flow direction (B).

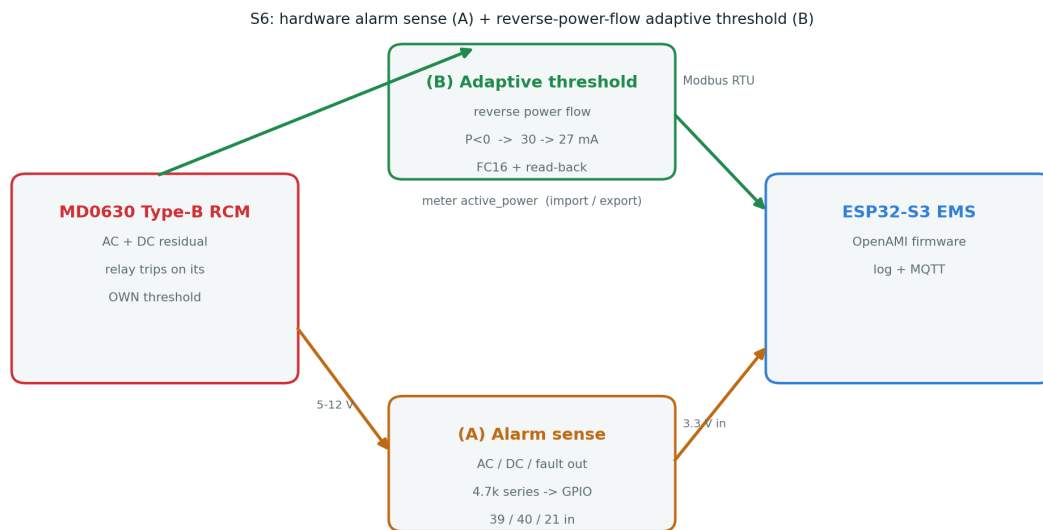


Figure 8: S6 architecture: hardware alarm sense (A) and reverse-power-flow adaptive threshold (B) between the MD0630 and the EMS.

(B) Reverse-power-flow adaptive threshold. Under export (PV or battery back-feed), the AC limit is tightened from 30 to 27 mA and restored on return to import. Export is detected

from the meter’s active power (below 50 W of back-feed). The threshold is re-written only on a debounced transition (three poll cycles), never every cycle, reusing the S3 FC16 write with read-back. The export flag is also passed to the S5 manager, which de-rates confidence under reverse flow.

(A) Hardware alarm sense. The MD0630 trips its own internal relay when leakage crosses a threshold. S6-A lets the EMS observe those AC/DC/fault alarm outputs so a trip is logged and published; it is read-only and never drives the trip. Each 5 V output reaches a GPIO through a single 4.7 k Ω series resistor, which is safe for any output type (an open-collector reads low when active; a push-pull 5 V high is clamped by the GPIO’s internal ESD diode, with the resistor limiting the current to about 0.36 mA).

During bench testing, three issues were found and fixed:

Table 6: S6-A issues found and fixed during hardware testing.

Issue found on hardware	Cause	Fix
Pins GPIO 33/34 absent on the devkit	not broken out on the ESP32-S3-DevKitC-1	move to GPIO 39/40/21
False AC=1 DC=1 at rest	outputs are active-high (low at rest, high on alarm)	<code>active_low=false</code> , <code>INPUT_PULLDOWN</code>
Manual pulse missed by the logger	alarm sampled only at the slow Modbus poll	fast service at about 50 Hz

After the fixes, the rest state reads quiet and a stimulus on the AC line is logged live:

```
SETUP: MODBUS: MD0630 alarm sense on GPIO 39/40/21 (AC/DC/fault, active-high)
S6 ALARM edge: AC=0 DC=0 FAULT=0      (at rest, no leakage, quiet)
S6 ALARM edge: AC=1 DC=0 FAULT=0      (A0 asserted, 3V3 pulse on GPIO39)
S6 ALARM edge: AC=0 DC=0 FAULT=0      (released; DC and FAULT stay 0)
```

S6 result

Both parts are implemented and gated behind build flags (the firmware builds cleanly with S6 off and with every S6 path on). **S6-A was verified on hardware:** the module alarm output reaches the GPIO through the 4.7 k Ω resistor and the firmware logs AC=1 within 200 ms. S6-B reuses the S3 write path.

8 Results summary

Table 7 collects the verification status of each capability. It distinguishes *code-proven* (exercised by the mock pipeline) from *hardware-proven* (validated against the physical module).

Table 7: Verification status across S1 to S6.

Capability	Verification	Status
Modbus link and register map (S1)	live device and vendor CT.exe frames	hardware-proven
Live AC/DC read (S2)	12/12 reads, 0 failures on the EMS	hardware-proven

Capability	Verification	Status
Threshold write and read-back (S3)	AC 30/27/30 mA on the EMS; FC16 traced	hardware-proven
Energy-change correlation (S4)	compiles; step to correlation via mock ramp	code-proven
Nomination and MQTT isolation (S5)	3-EMS round on one ESP32; live MQTT and charts	hardware-proven (mock peers)
Reverse-flow threshold (S6-B)	builds; transition-only FC16 write path	code-proven
Hardware alarm sense (S6-A)	live AC=1/AC=0 on the EMS, within 200 ms	hardware-proven

The firmware builds cleanly both in the default configuration (all leakage test flags off, no regression) and with every S1 to S6 capability compiled in, at about 19 % RAM and 28 % flash on the ESP32-S3. All source, drivers, per-sprint reports and diagrams are version-controlled on the `modbus-testing` branch.

References

1. *Faulty feeder identification in a distribution network by data analysis and similarity (trend-correlation) comparison of zero-sequence transients*, PMC7795609 (open access).
2. *FLISR: Fault Location, Isolation and Service Restoration*, workflow and practice.
3. *Additional criterion for faulty-feeder selection during ground faults using the residual voltage and residual current phase angle (about 90 degrees)*.
4. Modbus Organization, *MODBUS Application Protocol Specification*, V1.1b3.
5. IEC 60755, *General requirements for residual current operated protective devices*; IEC 62955 (residual DC detection for EV charging).
6. IVY Metering, *MD0630 Type-B AC+DC residual-current monitor*, datasheet and `CT.exe` tool (vendor).